royal family left, there were no fewer than thirteen candidates for the Scottish throne. The front-runners were Robert Bruce the Fifth, the dead king's second cousin, and John Balliol, a great-great-*great*-grandson of David I.

Robert Bruce had perhaps the best claim to the throne, and his son Robert Bruce the Sixth was well known to Edward; he had been on the Ninth Crusade with Edward and had helped the English campaign in Wales. But Robert the Fifth was already eighty years old, and Edward threw his weight behind John Balliol's candidacy. Balliol, a landowner in his forties, had no training as a soldier; he was married to an Englishwoman, owned an English estate, and already owed money to the English crown.[9]

A gathering of 104 Scottish aristocrats duly chose Balliol. "He was raised to the kingly seat at Scone," the *Chronicle of Lanercost* records, "with the applause of a multitude of people assembled, the King of England's attorneys also taking part." It was traditional for Scottish kings to be crowned at Scone Abbey, in the southeast of Scotland, while seated on the Stone of Scone: a chunk of sandstone said to have been brought to Scotland by the legendary first king of the Scots, Fergus, sixteen hundred years before.[10]

Having English officials help conduct the ceremony was definitely *not* traditional. But their presence was a sign of things to come.

Balliol agreed, shortly after his coronation, to do homage to Edward as his feudal lord. It was not a popular act; Edward immediately showed himself far too willing to meddle in Scottish affairs, and Balliol was unwilling to defy him. But for two years, the two men maintained an uneasy peace—until Edward and Philip of France fell out, giving the Scots a chance to rid themselves of their overbearing master to the south.

THE DEATH of Philip the Bold in France, after his ill-considered campaign in Aragon, left his seventeen-year-old son Philip IV on the throne. A year before his accession, the boy had been married off to Queen Joan of Navarre, aged ten; this had brought Navarre and France together under one royal couple.

Philip hero-worshipped his dead grandfather Louis, and hoped to model himself after Philip Augustus, his great-grandfather: both of them, kings with a high view of their divine calling as ruler. In the young Philip, this took the form of a great need to exert his authority over the independent-minded dukes who still held much of his kingdom. And the most independent-minded of these was Edward I, who was Duke of Aquitaine as well as king of England; Aquitaine, the home of Eleanor, wife of Henry II and mother of both Richard Lionheart and John Lackland, still remained under English control.

Philip was thus, theoretically, the feudal lord of Edward—just as Edward was the feudal lord of John Balliol. In 1294, the French king ordered Edward